

certed approach to the contest on the part of the Grand Alliance. It's clearly a case of 'united we stand, divided we fall', and the arrangement is still shaky as was evident last week when the TRS fielded candidates in at least 10 more than the 45 constituencies that were arrived at in their electoral understanding. Subsequently, in an embarrassing climbdown, both agreed to recall the additional contestants barely 48 hours before final withdrawal of nominations but the problem continued: some candidates

manner. There is widespread suspicion in the TDP that Rao has put up weak contestants in order to help the Congress. Opponents of the alliance in the TRP are apprehensive of Naidu reneging on the promise of carving out a separate state if the TDP comes to power. Naidu is optimistic about ironing out the issues but that could prove an uphill task. Desertions by legislators and other influential leaders, mostly heading for the PRP, has dampened his morale and of the TDP as well. This forced him to aban-

Pawan Kalyan for the PRP.

Mixing celluloid charisma with populist policies is now Naidu's electoral weapon. The TDP promises to provide colour television sets to every poor household if voted to power. The state is also to bear the cost of electricity supplied to these TV sets and will abolish entertainment tax which will benefit cable TV operators. He has also unveiled an innovative scheme involving a monthly payment of Rs 2,000 for the poorest of the poor, Rs 1,500 for the poor and Rs 1,000 for middle class households. This is to be transferred directly to the bank accounts of the woman beneficiary in the family who will be given an electronic cash card. "This has evolved after studying various international models and practices and during my Mee Kosam yatra," says Naidu. Other poll promises of the TDP include free medical care to the poor, free power supply to farmers, free supply of rice to the poor with a maximum monthly entitlement of 25 kg, besides monthly doles to the old, infirm and widows. But populism can only go so far if the alliance fails to project a united face.

WITH THE ARRANGEMENT BEING SHAKY AND THE ONGOING INFIGHTING, NAIDU NOW FACES A MULTI-CORNERED CONTEST.



CHIRANJEEVI DURING A ROAD SHOW IN ANANTAPUR DISTRICT

have stayed in the race as rebels. Though the TRS had won 26 Assembly and five Lok Sabha seats in 2004, it has suffered because of Rao's bizarre style of functioning and is a force only in north Telangana. Rao quit the UPA a year ago in protest against the delay in deciding on Telangana but in the by-elections that followed, the TRS won only seven Assembly and two Lok Sabha seats.

Mutual distrust among TDP and TRS activists has further dogged attempts to take on the Congress in a cohesive

don his traditional stand against a separate Telangana. Further, to neutralise the Chiranjeevi effect, he has roped in his actor brother-in-law Balakrishna to keep the glamour quotient alive. Significantly, the most popular cine star, Junior NTR, a lookalike of the patriarch and founder of the TDP was absent, having been injured in a road accident. That has proved a major setback to the party, badly in need of someone to match the popular posturing and histrionics of Chiranjeevi and his younger brother

Naidu knows the TDP cannot capture power on its own in what is a fragmented polity. "The Mahakutami has brightened the prospects of what was a weak TDP though it is certainly short on time for a meaningful campaign to convince voters about what they stand for, by putting forth an alternative economic programme," contends M. Kodandaram, professor, Political Science, Nizam College, Hyderabad. Further, there is no anti-incumbency wave like in 2004. The infighting is seriously damaging the image of his TDP besides the TRS. The communists are another negative, who are unable to give up their autocratic ways. While Chiranjeevi described the alliance as the "mayakutami" (illusory alliance), state Finance Minister Konjeti Rosaiah calls it a circus. That could well be accurate considering the tightrope walk Naidu has to perform to keep the alliance from falling apart. ■